

Alpha ex Machina Quick Reference

Your turn

1. **Margin, then refresh:** uncommitted funding sources pay Margin; then committed cards become available.
2. **Settle:** pay interest; collect office income and Yield (Patent Portfolio: Surplus or a card); from round 3, **Turtle Tax** per funding source under round - 1 (max 5): 1, +1 every 2 rounds; pay carrying costs or discard the card (the total rounds down).
3. **Refill** to your hand size (5; cards change it; min 2; a CEO in hand counts).
4. **Operate:** add 1 funding source (no immediate Margin); 1 staffing move (hire, replay a fired CEO, or open an office); buy tools; play investments, treaties, covers; run Surprise Inspections; use abilities; discard any cards.
5. **Close:** margin call (keep 1 Margin Credit per 10 Surplus); no hand limit.

Stress testing round after the last turn: in turn order, each company may run 1 Surprise Inspection; then delayed ones and the pile's top card hit every company; no runner. Never recycle used tests. Off your turn, play only Responses and that Inspection. **Setup:** CEO and HQ start on the board; draw 5 cards and redraw them once. Everyone shows 5 random deck cards, keeps their hand secret, then secretly picks 12/8/6 of 16 Stress Tests at 2/3/4 players for one 24-card pile. Fixed turn order.

Money

Overextend: once on your turn, commit non-core, non-NFT funding with printed exposures for 2 Leverage instead of 1. Printed exposures $\times 2$ until refresh; protection still applies. No next Margin. Unspent extra Leverage expires at turn end. Mark until refresh.

- **Leverage:** commit a funding source for 1; committed cards are available again next turn (on paper, slide them forward); unspent Leverage is lost.
- **Surplus:** your capital. 0 or less $\Rightarrow$ insolvent.
- **Alternate payment:** only when a card says so. Pay the full adjusted Leverage cost in Surplus, one for one; keep 1. Normal timing still applies. Cameron commits to allow this for one card costing 3 or less.
- **Margin:** uncommitted sources pay before refreshing. Insurance base: exposures minus 2 (minimum 1). Fixed Annuity, sources with carrying costs, and Financials: 0. Add bonuses. Auto-commit: lowest Margin first.
- **Hire:** pay Leverage. **Poach** (only cards that say so): Hire cost + 2 Surplus; not a staffing move; the poached employee gains Non-compete and arrives committed (gardening leave).
- **Price:** pay Leverage to buy a tool. Not a talent move; one of each; never poached or fired. Its exposures count like a funding source's.
- **Liquidate** any time: Sale value as Leverage or Surplus. Meme Stock waits until your next turn, even for forced sales.
- **Fire Sale:** during a Stress Test, after a sale by a company under 10 Surplus, everyone under 15 sells that investment for half its Sale value, rounded down.
- **Long vol:** when a Volatility Stress Test hits you, each VIX Calls or Long Straddle gains 10% of the table's loss.

Running a Stress Test

Settlement: a targeted inspection may offer: pay the runner 2 Surplus (keep 1), or contest with normal Responses. Settling skips losses and riders; card and cost remain spent. Payment changes final standings. No offer for Escalated, Systematic, pile, or replay events.

1. **Surprise Inspection:** pay its Leverage; choose the target.
2. **Response window:** left of the runner first, runner last; from the pile, the first player first. Responses, committed talent, offices, or tools, liquidation. No responses to responses.
3. **Stop:** cancel a Surprise Inspection. From the pile, a Stop protects only you. Acts of God can't be stopped.
4. **Resolve,** then check insolvency.

Emergency Equity Infusion: if a Bank Run would hit 2+ of your cards, one in the pile hits everyone at once, before the Stress Test in play. Everything Is Securities Fraud: when the Stress Test ends, its target loses what Stress Tests have cost it this round, again. Structured Notes: after caps, before recoveries.

Financials (banks and funds)

- **Retail Deposits:** Short-Term Rates exposure, except a third of them (rounded down), which have none; a bank run takes half,

rounded down, counting Venture Deposits and Evergreen Credit with them.

- **Investor Capital:** Short-Term Equity exposure.
- **Private Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost $1\frac{1}{2}$.
- **Margin Credit:** no exposure; carrying cost 1; margin call at the end of your turn.
- **Loans** (Credit Cards, Mortgage Lending, Prime Brokerage) are investments with a Credit exposure.

Headquarters and offices

HQ starts free on your board, outside the 40 cards, and stays. Pay **Open** in Leverage for a branch; it shares your staffing move. One of each city per company. Offices produce no Leverage, have no carrying cost, and cannot be poached or fired. Close a branch with no refund; never your HQ. **Fully Remote:** HQ only, no other offices. Offices with funding income pay 1 Surplus per 3 matching sources at turn start, rounded down; committed sources count. **Chicago** instead counts your three futures treaties together, including NFT copies. Opening an office does not refresh purchase discounts. Commit prevention is a total across matching clauses.

Drawing and discarding

Stress Tests draw nothing. Discard face up. To draw from an empty deck, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck and keep drawing. Stop only if both piles are empty.

Uncommit: make a different non-funding card you control available again. Executive Assistant and Delegation Dashboard each do this once between the starts of your turns. Readying or replaying them does not restore a spent use.

Who gets hit

Pile: every company · **Each opponent** (not you) · **Target opponent.** While any living company controls **Tail Dependence**, every Surprise Inspection is Systematic (you too) and cannot Escalate.

Loss math

Clause amount $\times$ (exposures - hedges, min 0). $\times 2$ counts twice. Nat Cat: Any matches every Nat Cat peril. Fixed exposures (Onion Farms) always count in full. Escalation keeps the same damage.

Quota Share, Side Letter, Catastrophe XoL, and Dynamic Hedging cost 1 Surplus a turn; other halving and loss-cap treaties have no carrying cost.

Protection order: failed Risk Management cards ("Destroyed if") $\rightarrow$ covers, ignores, flips $\rightarrow$ halving $\rightarrow$ flat reductions $\rightarrow$ swap payments $\rightarrow$ responses, talent, offices, and tools $\rightarrow$ XoL cap $\rightarrow$ recoveries.

Insolvency

Auto-sell liquid investments. Still at 0 or less: out. Too Big to Fail makes a failure cost everyone else 5 Surplus. If its fallout makes every remaining company fail after automatic sales, its controller wins. Qualifying controllers in the same final wave share the win.

Decks and table size

Deck: 40 cards plus 16 different Stress Tests (every Stress Test is Signature). 3 copies of a card; 1 of a **Signature** card; any number of a **Staple** card. **AI:** AI Bubble Bursts destroys it.

2-4 players. Everyone starts with 30 Surplus.

End after the last Stress Test or round 24. Finish all follow-ups. Rank by Surplus, uncommitted funding, total funding, then investment resale; exact ties share. At round 24, surviving **Cameron Ellis** controllers take priority and rank only against each other. Last solvent company can win earlier.

Keywords

Look ahead Scenario Planner or Early Warning System: commit to see the pile's top card. **Act of God** can't be stopped. **Developing Event** all stages this round, each with a response window. Delays expire after round 24. **Systematic** hits you too. **Escalate** pay 2 more Leverage to hit every opponent instead of one; same damage. **Illiquid** can't be sold. **Non-compete** can't be poached. **CEO** named Signature Talent; fixed for pre-made decks. Starts on the board for free. Never poached. Firing returns it to hand; replay it for its Hire in Leverage and a staffing move. Normal discards apply. **Dark** Stress Tests may charge separately per Dark card on your board and in your discard pile. Hand and deck do not count. The Paper Shredder removes discard evidence.